

Bookly

User Guide for business owners — take bookings, get paid, and answer customers automatically on WhatsApp.

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What Bookly does in one sentence: your customers message your WhatsApp number, an assistant books them in, takes a deposit, and reminds them — while you get on with the work.

1. Customer messages your WhatsApp

2. Assistant offers real free times

3. Booking made, deposit link sent

4. Reminder sent automatically

5. You see it all in your dashboard

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1. Before you start

You will need:

- A **phone number for your business** that is not already used on regular WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business on a phone. This becomes your Bookly number.
- A **Facebook/Meta business account** (free) to connect WhatsApp.
- A **Paystack account** if you want to collect deposits by mobile money or card. Optional, but strongly recommended.
- An email address you can access, for verification and password resets.

Plan 30–45 minutes for first-time setup. The WhatsApp connection is the longest part; everything after that is quick.

2. Create your account

- 1 Go to **bookly.ikieguy.online** and choose **Register**.
- 2 Enter your name, business name, email and a password (at least 8 characters), then agree to the terms.
- 3 Check your email and click the verification link. You can keep using Bookly before verifying — you'll just see a reminder banner.
- 4 You're in. Every new account starts on a **14-day free Pro trial**, so all features are unlocked while you set up.

Forgot your password later? On the login screen choose **Forgot password**, and we'll email you a reset link.

3. Connect WhatsApp

This is the most important step — until it's done, nothing can reach your customers.

- 1 Open **WhatsApp** in the menu.
- 2 Click **Connect WhatsApp Business**. A Facebook window opens.
- 3 Sign in to Facebook, pick (or create) your business, and choose the phone number you want to use.
- 4 Confirm the code Meta sends to that number.
- 5 Back in Bookly, the status turns **Live**. Send a test message to check.

If the Facebook window is blocked (ad-blocker, or it simply won't open), use **Connect manually instead** on the same page and paste the **Phone Number ID**, **WhatsApp Business Account ID** and **access token** from Meta → WhatsApp → API Setup.

Important: a number already active on the WhatsApp app on a phone cannot be used. Either use a fresh number, or delete the existing WhatsApp account on that number first.

4. Add your services

The assistant can only offer what you list here — it will never invent a service or a price.

1 Go to **Services** → **Add service**.

2 Fill in:

- **Name** — what customers will see, e.g. "Haircut".
- **Price** and **Duration in minutes** — duration controls how your day is split into slots.
- **Category** (optional) — to group services.
- **Deposit** (optional) — overrides your default deposit for this one service. Leave blank to use the default; set 0 for no deposit.

3 Keep **Active** on. Switch it off any time to hide a service without deleting it.

Get durations right — a 30-minute service and a 60-minute service produce completely different available times.

5. Set your working hours

1 Go to **Availability**.

2 Turn each day on or off, and set opening and closing times.

3 Press **Save working hours**.

Blackout dates

Closing for a holiday, a funeral, or travel? Add the date under **Blackout dates** with an optional reason. The assistant will not offer any time on those days.

Bookly only ever offers times that are genuinely free — it checks your hours, your blackout dates and your existing bookings before it says anything.

6. Get paid: deposits & Paystack

Deposits are the single biggest reason businesses stop losing money to no-shows. A customer who has paid something turns up.

Connect Paystack

- 1 Go to **Settings** and find the payments section.
- 2 Paste your **Paystack secret key** (from your Paystack dashboard).
- 3 Save. Customers can now pay by **mobile money or card**, and the money goes straight to your Paystack account — Bookly never holds your money.

Choose your deposit policy

Setting	Where	What it does
Ask for a deposit	Settings → Deposits	Master switch. Off = every booking is confirmed immediately with no payment.
Deposit amount	Settings → Deposits	The default amount asked for, in your account currency.
Per-service deposit	Services → edit a service	Overrides the default for that service. Set 0 for a service that needs no deposit.

How a deposit booking behaves

- The slot is **held for 30 minutes**, not confirmed. If the customer doesn't pay in that time, the slot is released for someone else.
- The assistant asks whether they'd like to **pay now** or **pay when they arrive**.
- Choose **pay now** → it sends a real Paystack link. Paying confirms the booking instantly.
- Choose **pay on arrival** → the booking is confirmed and you collect on the day.
- If a customer asks later "how do I pay?", the assistant finds their unpaid booking and re-sends the link.

If **Paystack isn't connected**, no payment link can be created. Bookly confirms the booking anyway and tells the customer to pay on arrival — and notifies you so nothing is lost silently.

7. Your day-to-day: the dashboard

Overview is your morning screen. It shows:

- Total bookings, **today's bookings**, active chats and total customers.
- Whether WhatsApp is **Live** or needs attention.
- Recent activity, so you can see what happened overnight.

8. Bookings

The **Bookings** page lists every appointment. Use the filter chips to switch between All, Confirmed, Pending, Completed and Cancelled.

Status	Meaning
Pending payment	Held, waiting for the deposit. Released if unpaid after 30 minutes.
Confirmed	Locked in. Deposit paid, or no deposit needed.
Completed	The appointment happened.
Cancelled	Cancelled by you or the customer.
No show	They didn't turn up.

Open any booking to see the customer, service, time and reference, message them on WhatsApp in one tap, resend a payment link, or cancel.

Adding a booking yourself

Walk-in or phone booking? Add it from the Bookings page. Bookings you create are **confirmed straight away with no deposit** — Bookly assumes you're handling payment in person. It still checks the slot is genuinely free.

9. Chats & taking over from the assistant

Chats is your WhatsApp inbox. Every customer conversation appears here.

- A **green dot** means the customer spoke last and is waiting on a reply.
- A badge shows who is handling it: **Bot** or **You**.
- Open a chat and simply type to reply — the assistant steps aside automatically.
- Press **Resume bot** to hand it back when you're done.

The assistant also hands over to you by itself when a customer asks for a person, sounds frustrated, or asks something outside bookings.

10. The 24-hour rule & message templates

This is a WhatsApp rule, not a Bookly limitation, and it surprises everyone at first.

You can only send free-typed messages within 24 hours of the customer's last message.
Outside that window, WhatsApp only allows pre-approved **templates**.

What this means in practice:

- While a customer is chatting with you, reply freely — no restriction.
- A day later, you cannot just type "Hi, are you coming?". The message box will tell you the window has closed.
- **Reminders and confirmations still work**, because Bookly sends those as approved templates.

Templates

The **Templates** page lists your Meta-approved message templates and whether each is **Approved** or **Pending**. You register templates in WhatsApp Manager; Bookly uses them for booking confirmations, reminders and cancellations.

If reminders aren't arriving, check here first — an unapproved or missing template is the usual cause.

11. The mobile app

The Bookly app gives you the same business on your phone, with **push notifications** — the main reason to install it.

Tab	What it's for
Overview	Today's numbers and WhatsApp status.
Bookings	Your appointments, with filters and details.
Chats	Reply to customers; unread count on the tab.
Services	Add and edit services and prices.
More	Notifications, Availability, Templates, WhatsApp, Team, Settings.

Allow notifications when asked — you'll get an alert the moment a booking comes in or a customer replies. Under **Settings → Appearance** you can force Light or Dark, or follow your phone.

12. Your team

Only the **owner** can manage the team. Go to **Team** (in More on mobile) to:

- **Add a member** — name, email and a temporary password to share with them. They can log in and handle bookings and chats.
- **Switch someone off** when they leave — this blocks access without deleting their history.

The owner account cannot be deactivated, and you cannot deactivate yourself.

13. Plans, usage & promo codes

Bookly charges by how many WhatsApp messages you send out each month. Your cycle runs 30 days from the day you signed up, not from the 1st.

Plan	Price / month	Messages	Services	Team	Templates
Free	\$0	50	3	1	3
Starter	\$19	500	Unlimited	3	Unlimited
Pro	\$49	5,000	Unlimited	Unlimited	Unlimited

Settings → **Plan & usage** shows your plan, your status (Trial, Active, Past due or Cancelled) and a bar for messages used this cycle. The bar turns amber near your limit and red when you've hit it.

If you run out of messages, the assistant cannot reply to customers until the cycle resets or you upgrade. Watch the bar.

Promo codes

Given a code? Enter it under **Settings** → **Plan & usage** → **Have a promo code?** and press **Apply code**. It will either extend your trial or put you on a plan, and Bookly confirms the new end date.

14. Other settings

Setting	What it does
Your name / Business name	Your business name is what the assistant calls you when greeting customers.
Timezone	Every time shown to customers uses this. Set it correctly before taking bookings.
Automated reminders	Sends booking reminders outside the 24-hour window. Turning it off saves messaging cost but customers get no reminder.
Google Calendar	Connect to have confirmed bookings appear in your calendar automatically.
SMS fallback	Add Arkesel details so that if WhatsApp delivery fails, the customer still gets an SMS.
Email fallback	Add your Gmail address and app password as a last resort if both WhatsApp and SMS fail.
Appearance	Light, Dark, or follow your device (mobile app).

Set up at least one fallback. Messages occasionally fail for reasons outside anyone's control; a fallback means the customer still hears from you.

15. What the assistant can and cannot do

It can	It will not
• List your services with real prices • Offer only genuinely free times • Create, hold and confirm a booking • Look up a customer's own bookings • Send a real deposit payment link • Hand the chat over to you	• Invent a service, price or free slot • Make up or alter a payment link • Double-book a taken slot • Offer times outside your hours or on a blackout day • Keep guessing — it asks for you instead

Anything with money or a commitment runs through the same checks your dashboard uses, so the assistant cannot promise something your diary can't honour.

16. Troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause & fix
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Customers message and nothing happens	WhatsApp isn't connected, or the number is wrong. Check the WhatsApp page shows Live and send a test message.
The assistant says no times are available	Working hours are off for that day, it's a blackout date, or the service duration doesn't fit. Check Availability and the service duration.
"You can only send a template" when replying	The 24-hour window has closed. Wait for the customer to message, or send an approved template. See section 10.
Deposit link never arrives	Paystack isn't connected, or the service has no deposit set. Check Settings → payments and the service.
Reminders not sending	Automated reminders switched off, no approved reminder template, or you've hit your message limit.
Slot disappeared after a customer booked	Normal — an unpaid held booking is released after 30 minutes so others can book it.
Can't log in	Use Forgot password. If your account was switched off by the owner, ask them to re-enable it.
No push notifications on the phone	Notifications were declined at install. Enable Bookly notifications in your phone's settings.

17. Frequently asked questions

Do my customers need to install anything?

No. They use normal WhatsApp. That's the whole point.

Can I still reply myself?

Yes, any time. Open the chat and type — the assistant steps back automatically and waits until you hand it back.

Does Bookly hold my money?

No. Payments go directly to your own Paystack account.

Can I use my personal WhatsApp number?

Not if it's currently active on the WhatsApp app. Use a separate business number — it's cleaner anyway.

What happens when my trial ends?

Your account moves to the Free plan (50 messages a month). Your data stays; upgrade whenever you're ready.

Can two people use it at once?

Yes. Add them under Team — subject to your plan's team limit.

Is it only for salons?

No. Anything booked by appointment works — clinics, barbers, tutors, consultants, mechanics, photographers — and shops can take orders instead.

18. Getting help

- **Support page** — bookly.ikieguy.online/support
- **In the app** — Settings has your plan and account details, useful when reporting an issue.
- **When reporting a problem**, include: your business name, what you expected, what happened, and the customer's phone number if it involves a chat. It gets you a fix far faster.

Your first week checklist

1. Connect WhatsApp and send yourself a test message.
2. Add every service with the correct price and duration.
3. Set working hours and any blackout dates.
4. Connect Paystack and decide your deposit amount.
5. Install the mobile app and allow notifications.
6. Put your WhatsApp number on your Instagram bio, shopfront and receipts — customers can't book a number they don't know.

Bookly User Guide v1.0 · September 2026. Features and plan limits may change; your dashboard always shows what's current.